

The Post-Pandemic Bifurcation: Democratisation vs Oligarchy Radicalisation in the Arab World

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Abstract

The centrality of the call for dignity during the Arab revolutions that broke out in late 2010 signified a demand for change requiring a radical reconstruction of the political system, which goes beyond a shy historical compromise. Soon after the fall of the regimes in Tunisia, and Egypt, a confrontation started between the unprepared seekers of change, and the incapable tattered old regimes and their local and external patrons in a range of Arab countries. The confrontation utilised a multiplicity of forms and tools that had destabilisation in common (including the destabilisation of the destabilisers). While the torn states were reduced to their essential component – security, the pandemic emerged leading to a situation of further destabilisation, and more nuanced de-legitimisation of the shattered regimes. The pandemic hit the already distressed states' capacity to protect citizens' lives, not to mention wellbeing. This situation obviously poses a challenge to the *raison d'être* of the regimes pushing them towards further securitisation. The confrontation will move to a new threshold once the Pandemic is behind us, and the populous are able to go down to the streets again. The next round of confrontations will be either radical democratisation, or a radicalisation of the oligarchy.

Introduction

After record-breaking durations of political power retention in Arab countries for which the Algerian novelist Waciny Laredj used the coined term “*repubdoms*”², multi-decade rulers were falling after the revolts that erupted starting late 2010. *The Arab Dignity Revolutions* were not only an expression of misery and disenchantment with the existing order, a feeling that a threat is to be encountered, but also a belief that change is possible:

People... knew that a time had ended, and that another time was set on the horizon with a lot of certainty, perhaps more merciless, but they swore to change everything, even the deceptive timings and times that were set to the pulse of the ruler by self-command, the owner of the Repubdom of Arabia. (الأعرج 2011، 11)

While the revolts have undoubtedly created a temporal-spatial break with the political past in spite of being undermined by the counter-revolutions, the pandemic interrupted a second wave of political turmoil. It added a layer of threat and misery to the masses, created an additional temporary fortification for regimes, and produced some scepticism concerning the revolts' and the *hiraks*' outcomes.

The pandemic stalled some of the techniques of regime contestation: physical collective protest in the squares was not a choice anymore; while the state, with its security apparatus, was deemed necessary and inevitable at this moment. However, the pandemic will not last forever, and a “new life” will supervene it. “Historically, pandemics have forced humans to break with the past and imagine their world anew. This one is no different. It is a portal, a gateway between

¹ I would like express my gratitude for the helpful comments from the reviewers and the editors.

² *Jumlukiyyat* (جُمْلُكِيَّات) is a term that combines (in plural) syllables from the two terms republic “*Jumhourieh*” (جمهورية), and kingdom “*mamlakah*” (مملكة).

one world and the next.” (Roy 2020) What need answers are the questions about the nature of the new world, its Arab part in particular, and about the actors who shall shape it.

The Arab World is witnessing a popular demand for restructuring. It is also witnessing a new wave of proxy wars, and escalating regional tensions. A significant novelty in the scene is that the “silent masses” shrunk (and keep shrinking) and are speaking out. Conversely, those who are satisfied with the status quo and animus to change are still resourceful. A clear division has emerged between them and those who believe that the time has come to reshape their countries based on new foundations. This polarization process generates new aspects that will affect the dynamics of its unfolding, such as new alliances and political cleavages, political undercurrents, and conflicts. Throughout this phase of polarisation, everyone will position themselves in a way which will maximize their role in shaping the next order, because the struggle for the future is a struggle between the forces of the present.

In 2010 Muhammad Al-Bouazizi set himself on fire, instigating a revolt in Tunisia, which echoed in several Arab countries creating *the Arab dignity revolutions*. Ten years later George Floyd was killed in cold blood in a manifestation of racism, instigating a global wave of protest that was entrenched in the movement “Black Lives Matter”. If, in some aspect, the reaction to the 2010 incident was a blueprint of that of 2020, one should wonder if the Global South would initiate the change towards the “next world”, and whether the *dignity revolutions* were the prelude of this change. “Evidence of commonality abounds in the global squares of protest and in the triggers of discontent. All of these protest groups seem to embrace, at least rhetorically, an emancipatory mantra of freedom and dignity.” (Sadiki 2016, 327)

This mantra of dignity indicated a transformative threshold, which overlaps with the “notion of ‘reflexive modernization’ [that] panders to a moral agenda, which remains unfulfilled in the Arab world on count of the undeniable persistence of inequity and discrimination.” (Sadiki and Saleh 2020, 6) The revolution deems to achieve this moral agenda through the shaping of the public will and reshaping the public sphere in a manner that allows the moral dimension to be transposed from the private sphere to the public sphere, apprise the political, and monopolise it. The popular chanting of “dignity” is a signifier of protesting the old “dignitaries” – an epochal significance indicating the need for foundational change that amounts to the reformulation of the social contract through “reflexivity”, which “demands measuring up to moral standards that consider the right to safety for all and matching ethics that resist top-down and exclusionary orders of governmentality.” (Sadiki and Saleh 2020, 15)

Dignity revolutions are a quest for a new order that overcomes the current state of inequality, vulnerability, and societal fragmentation and exclusion. They are a quest for radical democratisation that does not conform to the prevailing perceptions of Western liberal democracy. This non-conformity lends global significance to these revolutions. The COVID-19 pandemic has a dual effect on the quest for democratisation: stagnation and radicalisation; while its effect on the counter-revolutionary forces is radicalising.

Outlining or sketching the “reflexive” social contract is an impossible task, but the “dignity” slogan signposts some of its intended ingredients and trends. These include the universalisation of equality (beyond civil-political to the socio-economic and cultural, and beyond precarity); freedom; and the autonomy of will which once collectivised creates sovereignty, rather than being embedded in the sovereign and reduced to it.

In this chapter, understanding the *dignity revolutions* as a phenomenon of global significance, we will sketch the active counter-revolutionary powers; and look into the (possible) impact of the COVID-19 pandemic on the dynamics of change in the Arab World; and finally, speculate on the chances of the creation of a “new world” from a regional perspective. The chapter

commences with these tasks with the realisation that neither the *dignity revolutions* nor the pandemic is behind us, and we cannot evaluate either of them before we observe their finale. It is a speculation about what is still unfolding.

The Revolution

The *dignity revolutions*³ can serve as a point of reference for this discussion. “Starting points” in history are contestable, but the turmoil that erupted in the Arab World in late 2010 is itself a culmination and a prelude. The *dignity revolutions* had multiple interrelated characteristics: scale, concentration, significance, direction, suddenness, and peacefulness. However, the most relevant for our analysis is their revelation that is inscribed in the transnational slogan “dignity”, the use of which as a political slogan in the region is novel. The slogans of the *dignity revolutions* encompassed a range of demands that in essence contested the entirety of the status quo in the Arab World. The “dignity” slogan introduced a socio-economic dimension to political movements that has been missing for decades, and represented the bond between the social and the political. It moved beyond the nation and the state.

Revolutions result from structural failures. Their slogans reflect the nature and deepness of existing defects. The breadth of chanting “dignity” urges the discovery of its signified. It was voiced in many countries, but we confine this discussion to the revolutions in Tunisia and Egypt, as they were, unlike Syria, Yemen, and Libya, void of blatant foreign intervention, and realised a quantum leap (even if the new orbit was pushed back) towards ending regime perpetuity.

The revolutions that occurred in Tunisia and Egypt embraced the most archetypical representative of the state – the army. They did not take place as a result of an emergent condition, rather, they took place in response to two regimes plunged into methodical and, arguably, successful reform programmes.⁴ They were as much revolutions against these reforms as they were revolutions against the status quo that the two regimes implied.

Revolutionary Demands

The centrality of the dignity slogan signifies that the policies of the former regimes, including the reforms they were undertaking, tampered with the dignity of society. *Dignity revolutions* were “not just a revolt against authoritarian regimes but also expressions of a systemic crisis, a structural crisis of the social order of neoliberal globalization.” (Bogaert 2013, 214) People did not believe that the reform processes would improve their chances of becoming respectable citizens. The regime infringed on their dignity. It did not only meddle with the living circumstances of citizens but with them directly. The nature of the security doctrine imposed by the globalized unipolar neo-liberal world order made tampering with dignity inevitable.

Dignity, as a signifier, does not have a well-defined or concrete signified. It expresses insistence on some values concerning people with different, sometimes contradicting, connotations. While democracy was an obvious popular demand, and dignity was a widely chanted slogan during the peaks of protest and revolt, a retrospective sorting of public priorities does not give dignity or democracy a significant weight. In figure (1) below, only some 8% of

³ For a more elaborate analysis of the Arab Dignity Revolutions by the author, see “Arab Dignity Revolutions: A Post-Neoliberal View” [in Arabic]. (قسييس، ثورات الكرامة العربية ومفهوم الكرامة 2012)

⁴ It is worth noting here that Tunisia had the highest national income per capita among the non-oil producing Arab countries, except for Lebanon. Egypt witnessed high growth rates in the years preceding the revolution (around 7% on average annually since 1980).

those who provided a positive response chose democracy or dignity as the most important reason for the outbreak of *dignity revolutions*.

Figure (1): Most important reasons for the outbreak of the Arab Spring in polls across Arab countries according to poll of 2019-2020

The reasons	Most important reasons
Against corruption	31
Due to poor economic conditions	16
Against dictatorship	16
For political freedoms	6
To end oppression	6
For justice and equality	4
For democracy	3
For dignity	4
Other	1
don't know, decline to respond	13
No other choice	0
Total	100

Source: Arab Center for Research and Policy Studies - Results of Arab Opinion Index 2019-2020 (Arab Center for Research and Policy Studies 2020, 11)

The majority of the answers in the above table identify what respondents **do not** want: corruption, poverty, dictatorship, and oppression. This is a typical reflection of “doxastic anxiety”. As figure (1) above demonstrates, no respondents to the question about the causes of the revolts opted for the answer “no other choice” – i.e. respondents were consciously seeking purposeful change – a drive towards a new order.

The significance of the slogan

The chanting of dignity designates a call to overcome exclusionary features of the contemporary world order. This is not the first time in modern history that it surfaces. It was used for supporting the cancellation of slavery in Tunisia in the mid-nineteenth century, and by Tunisian president Habib Bourguiba, who used the phrase ‘once women regain their dignity...’. (Al-Argash 2013)

There is basis to assume that the dignity slogan surfaces when the aspired change is “epochal” - seeks to move to a new historical phase. The demand is not only for regime change, but rather for changing its foundations, demanding the termination and reformulation of the existing social contract. (قسيس 2012)

The use of the dignity slogan for revolution or by popular movements indicates a shift of the realm in which it operates, from the private (individual, moral) to the public (political). Such a shift that takes place spontaneously reflects the will of the private (individual, family, group) entity to participate in the shaping of the public (social, political, national) entity. It assumes the existence of a drive to realise the private will outside the private sphere. It assumes the cognition of a historical moment, in a historical movement that has a claim on making history – a transformative historical process.

While acknowledging the importance of the shift of the concept of dignity to the political sphere, one must distinguish clearly between the elite initiative to position centrally the concept

in the state super-structures (e.g. legislation) and the popular demand for dignity. The central question here is: what instigates the popular demand for something that might seem to obscure “its economic and social aspects and the aspirations of its initiators”? (Beinin 2016, 101) Why does the popular common sense, which usually avoids abstraction, embrace this slogan at times? The public utilises this concept to express and condense the entirety of popular demand - achieving a new historical era. A comparison between the *bread revolutions* in the late eighties of the past century and the *dignity revolutions* can easily expose the differences, including the latter’s insistence on ousting and destroying regime symbols.

To summarise, we can formulate three conclusions. The first is that the popular use of the dignity slogan indicates the desire to trigger change of “epochal” nature. The second conclusion is that the revolutionary form of political expression signifies an irreversible process of the objectification of collective subjective wills, i.e. there is no going back from the new epoch to the old one (even if they look similar). The third conclusion is that the demands of the *dignity revolutions* go beyond the Arab political regimes: slogans pointed to the world order. *Dignity revolutions* are Arab revolutions that belong to a globalised era. They simultaneously confronted their local totalitarian regime and the oligarchical world order. Their emancipatory dimensions are dual as well, challenging the prevailing perceptions of Western liberal democracy (in its neoliberal form). Hence, the use of the dignity slogan also found global resonance.

The Significance of the Achievements and Shortcomings of the *Dignity Revolutions*

The forces of the revolution are not homogenous, and their consensus over the dignity slogan does not signify one single signified. One can imagine various perspectives ranging from ones of a liberal nature (related mainly to individual civil rights) to others of a social nature, related primarily to economic and social rights because “many of the socio-economic grievances remain, or are worse in 2021 than in 2010.” (Sadiki and Saleh 2021) Taking one without the other is a betrayal of some of the forces.

The *dignity revolutions* interacted with at least three traits: (a) the impact of globalization on the nature of the state; (b) the redistribution of labour and wealth among countries due to the hegemony of unadorned market values over the globalization process; and (c) the new security doctrine, which (over)empowered the coercive state, and shifted the main function of the state to the protection of external interests to the detriment of its original role of serving as a security and protection umbrella for its citizens, national identity, and sovereignty. Thus, safeguarding dignity became an urgent and vital popular demand to divert the nature of globalization from corporate globalization to solidarity.⁵

What constitutes the success or failure of the *dignity revolutions* is not the form of the emerging regime, but its potential and capacity to enact a radical democratisation by adopting economic and political programmes that can overcome or counterbalance neo-liberal policies. The distinctive attribute of such democratisation is inclusion and not market liberalisation. In this sense and context, any regime that cannot safeguard dignity is, by definition, counter-revolutionary.

⁵ Google N-grams show a 44% growth in the frequency of the presence of “solidarity” in Google’s text corpora in English between 1991-2016.

(https://books.google.com/ngrams/graph?content=solidarity&year_start=1991&year_end=2016&corpus=26&smoothing=0)

“Everyone (almost without exception) agrees ... to condemn the economic and social policies of the ousted President Hosni Mubarak's regime, as well as to talk somehow about their bias towards ‘social justice’ ... And they conclude the same conclusion: the need to encourage the private sector.” (کساب 2015) This also applies to “third way” regimes that took the form of political Islam, which provides (and imposes) an identity, but hides its positions concerning welfare. In a similar fashion, civil society organisations had, and will continue to have an extremely limited impact on the revolutionary process.⁶

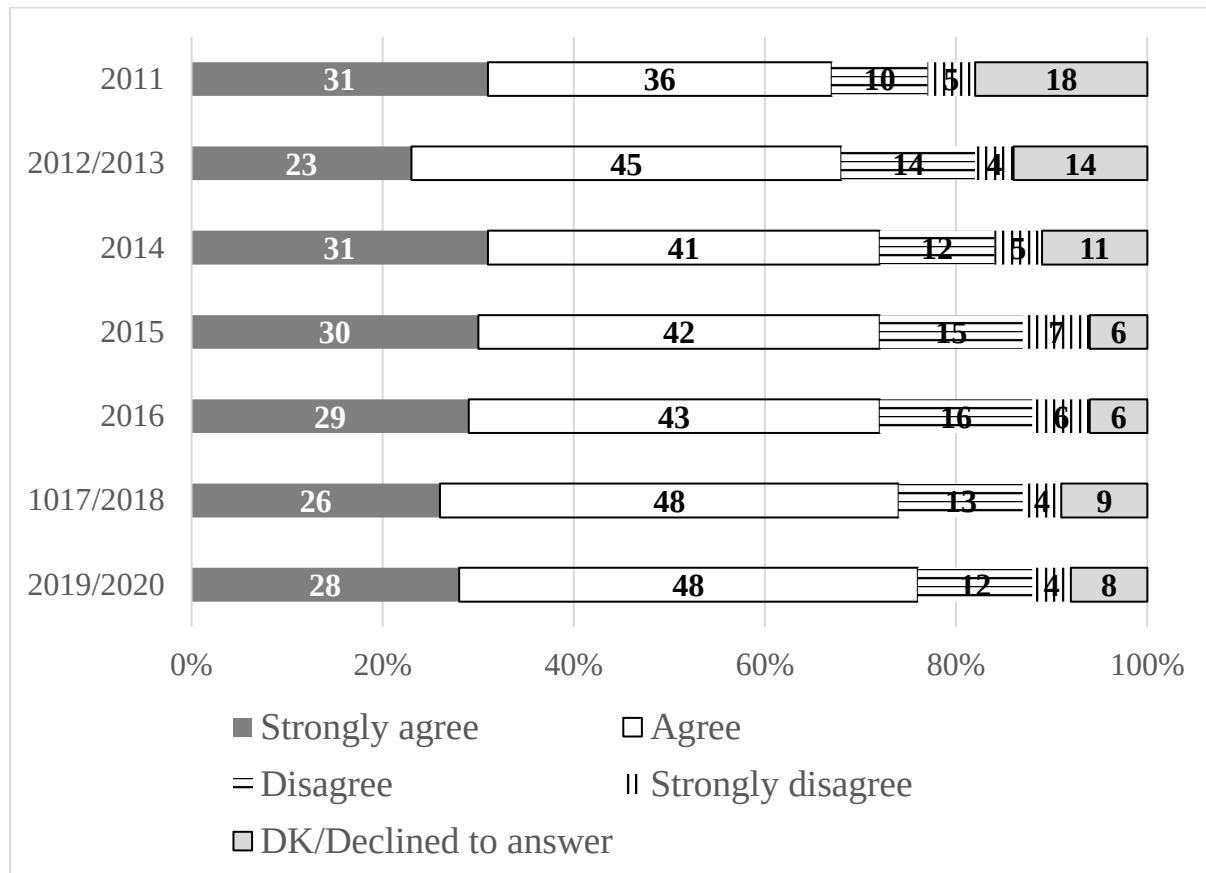
The *dignity revolutions* succeeded in declaring the decay of the old regimes, in challenging the monopoly over politics, in forcing change, and in declaring the advent of a new era. The revolt against the monopoly over politics was evident, not only in the insistence of ousting Mubarak, Ben Ali, Bouteflika, and Albashir, but more so in the massive protest⁷ against popularly elected Egyptian president Morsi on 30 June 2013, after one year of electing him.

Between the years 2011 and 2020, more than two thirds and up to three fourths of poll respondents expressed support for democracy, and between 6% and 18% declined to express a position. As figure (2) below shows, support for democracy is rising slowly, while scepticism is declining.

⁶ For a discussion of CSOs future choices, see (قسيس 2020).

⁷ It is important not to mix up the massive protest of 30 June 2013 with the military take-over of power of 3 July 2013. It is obvious that protests of 30 June were a culmination of a process, contaminated with various internal and external counter-revolutionary elements. However, exploiting the disillusionment of the masses does not negate the fact of disillusionment. Joel Beinin cites strikes of nearly forty thousand workers in December 2012, and “1,972 collective actions during the first six months of 2013, the last months of Morsi’s rule.” (Beinin 2016, 117) The eventual capturing of power by Sisi on 3 July is a separate process that served as the culmination of the counter-revolutionary conspiracy that accompanied the protests.

Figure (2): Support for the statement “Democracy remains better than other forms of government, despite its shortcomings” in polls across Arab countries during the years 2011-2020



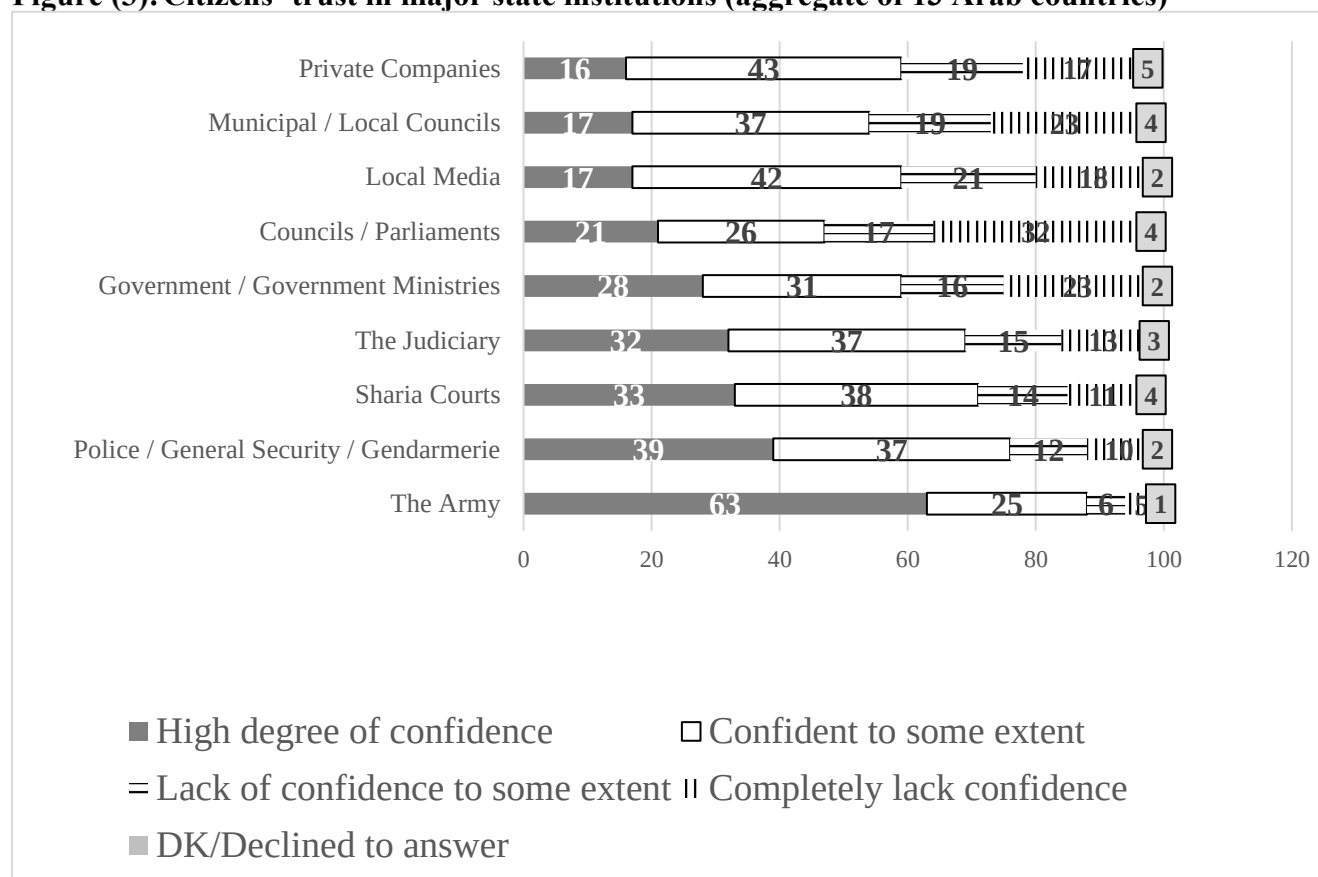
Reconstructed using data from source: Arab Center for Research and Policy Studies - Results of Arab Opinion Index 2019-2020 (Arab Center for Research and Policy Studies 2020, 2)

The most evident shortcoming of the *dignity revolutions* is their inability to provide a replacement regime, or a new leadership. The “third way” politics and the accompanying “political corporations” that prevailed in the three decades preceding the *dignity revolutions* are still in place. Political oppositions in the Arab World were, and still are, largely part of the regime-system. They have different answers to the questions posed by the establishment, but they do not pose their own questions. The fate of Egypt under Sisi, the threat to the nascent Tunisian democracy by Saied, and the military coup of October 2021 in Sudan are witness to the price of the political immaturity of revolutions.

“Political corporations” act as ruling parties that do not operate in accordance with known party structures. They control all the branches of political authority, the job market, security, culture, and media. By monopolising the political realm, they undermine the very notion of opposition, whose efficacy hinges on defeating the entirety of the system. Opposition, thus, has to either suffice with low profile, inefficient, verbal opposition with an ever-shrinking constituency; or resort to radical forms of protest and organisation frequently utilising violence, and adopting an ideological blanket of populist, and conspiracy theory discourse. For that, it utilises various types of identitarian mantras, which reshape politics by transforming struggle by contesting politics through splitting rather than sharing it. In such a situation, political participation becomes meaningless, and the very idea of citizenship loses ground.

In the absence of a political alternative to the regime, the revolutionary forces were deprived of political organisation and leadership to the extent that they had no choice but to resort to the army for political leadership. The army, being the archetypical representation of the “political establishment” – a corporation itself, volunteered to lend itself to the revolution as a bridge to power. It was not perceived as a replacement, nor did it pretend to be one, but it conditioned its role of bridging on ensuring that the other end of the bridge leads to where its allies stay operative and powerful. The army was ready for this role for at least three reasons: (a) its “low profile” role in politics is the norm; (b) it has a relatively autonomous network of external relations that is instrumental in importing external legitimacy for a “future regime”; and (c) it bases its legitimacy on capacity and merit and not on any form of representation. As figure (3) below demonstrates, trust in the army and other security institutions is significantly higher than all other institutions (including representative institutions and judiciaries).

Figure (3): Citizens’ trust in major state institutions (aggregate of 13 Arab countries)



Reconstructed using data from source: Arab Center for Research and Policy Studies - Results of Arab Opinion Index 2019-2020 (Arab Center for Research and Policy Studies 2020, 6)

The *dignity revolutions* failed to set the direction of change. The maximum they achieved in the four Arab countries where they succeeded in ousting a regime, without jumping into a civil/proxy war (Tunisia, Egypt, Sudan, and Algeria), was enforcing tools for political change that are not, on their own, sufficient to ensure change. In Egypt, in combination with the army, they produced a Moslem Brotherhood regime that was popularly rejected a year later opening the door to a ferocious return of the old regime with army blessing and protection, and external intervention to the detriment of democratisation. In Tunisia, it produced a political system built on the liberal assumptions of elite contestation with little consideration for popular will. The system has not been stable since its emergence and stumbled into a series of crises until it came to point when President Saied liquidated the central structures of liberal democracy. In Sudan, the revolution had to come to a transitional arrangement that could provide room for either

fostering the revolutionary powers, or buying time for counter-revolutionary powers supported by an assortment of external forces. The military coup that took place on 25 October 2021 confirmed the latter tendency, while the massive protests against the military rule provide hope for a revolutionary revival.

It is still early to evaluate the eventual impact of the *dignity revolutions*, but the status of the countries where they fruited, with reference to their demands and slogans, does not reflect success. The lack of accountability repudiated political liberalisation and warranted its reversibility. Not long after the liberalisations were instigated in the late 1980s, a new security doctrine thrived, and political liberalisation was moved to a back-burner until it was completely abandoned in favour of neo-liberalisation. “[T]he years between 2003 through the beginning of 2011 saw a dramatic increase in the speed, depth, and seeming dominance of neoliberal reforms.” (Haddad 2017, 75) This neo-liberalisation process was a major factor in prompting the *dignity revolutions*, but at the same time, served as their embedded limitation. Internal and external factors and actors facilitated the post-revolutionary triumph of alliances involving the Brotherhood and allies and protégés of old regimes, resulting in reducing revolutionary demands to their textual and formal dimensions. As a result, post-revolutionary regimes faltered.

The *dignity revolutions* were a turmoil themselves, and created one. The prevailing neoliberal policies and its post-political culture came to a dead end. Like every decay, they became self-destructive. The *dignity revolutions* utilised the “master’s tools to dismantle the master’s house”, but they could not master its reconstruction because they lacked adequate political organisation, and because of the strengths of the counter-revolutionary forces, and their access to resources that the *dignity revolutions* did not manage to cut. Having said this, the Arab World today is not similar to that of 2010. The revolutions turned out to be contagious in the short and the long terms. Arab countries are not seen, at least by the populous, as encapsulated. The revolutions in Sudan and Algeria clearly demonstrated a pattern of lesson-learning from the successes and failures of their predecessors. Yet the direction and pace of change in both countries indicates that there is more to learn.

The *dignity revolutions* set new thresholds that are yet to be achieved. These include, inter alia: (a) political pluralism - the rejection of monopoly over politics; (b) universality and unity of rights - the criticality of social, economic, and cultural rights; (c) political engagement – the need for political organisation beyond civil society activism and social movements; (d) inclusiveness of democracy – the insufficiency of procedures for democracy, and the necessity of a moral component in politics; and (e) pre-eminence of communities – collective rights and action, and the irreducibility of democracy to Western liberal democracy. Multiple aspects of the second wave of the *dignity revolutions* confirm “progress” towards the set thresholds. As Alyssa Miller writes in her analysis of the role of the anticorruption campaign *Manish Msamah* [I do not forgive] which emerged in Tunisia in 2015:

The campaign is revealed as an early participant in the ‘second wave’ of the Arab Spring, which has refused the lure of procedural democracy in favor of deeper structural change. (Miller 2021, 205)

Dignity revolutions, acquiring global significance, made clear that the Arab World cannot be researched in isolation, nor can it be solely a “recipient” of global impacts, that “we must guard against mono-causal explanations of politics in the Arab Middle East,” (Sadiki 2016, 338) and that the nation-state approach to analysis cannot explain the political processes in the region. (Sadiki 2016, 336) It also made clear that the modernisation theory is incapable of unrolling a roadmap for reshaping the Global South. On the contrary, the Global South is taking part in reshaping democracy globally.

The Counter-Revolution

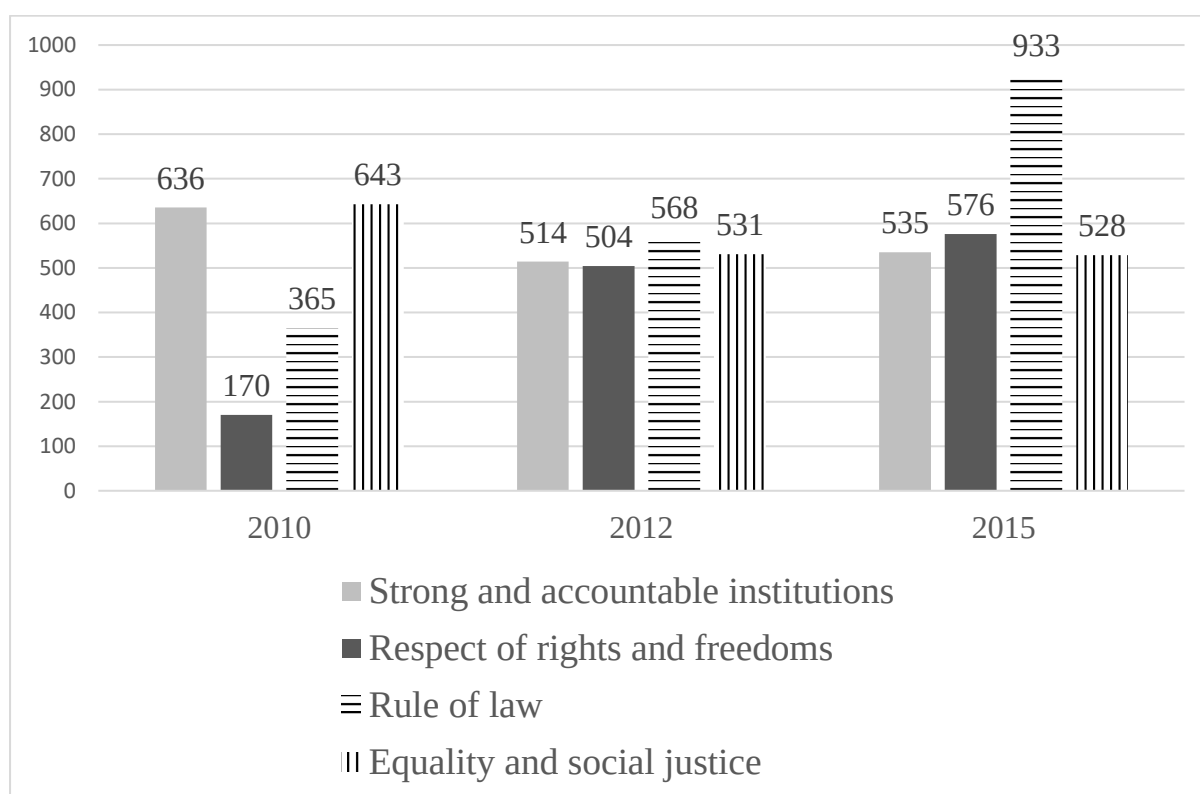
Counter-revolution is an inevitable reaction to any revolution. *Dignity revolutions* are not an exclusion neither collectively nor in the particularity of each of the countries where they erupted. Powers, whose interests are transgressed by the revolution, commence counter-actions to protect and maintain their pre-revolution status and benefits. They embark on counter-actions to stop the revolutionary endeavour's effect and potential, reverse its realised impact or redirect it, and dry out its resources.

The preliminary success of the *dignity revolutions* in Egypt, Tunisia, Sudan, and Algeria, led the counter-revolutionary powers to declare initially their support to the revolution. They turned their back to regime symbols, but acted to protect those components of the political system that constitute their source of interest, secure their privilege, and maintain tools for control. They opted to desert the regime, but salvage the establishment. According to Kais Saied (interviewed 6 years before he became Tunisian president), the slogan "*Tunis hurra hurra w Bin Ali barra*" [Tunisia is free, Bin Ali out] was replaced, after the establishment of the Higher Authority for Realisation of the Objectives of the Revolution, Political Reform and Democratic Transition in March 2011, with the slogan "*alsha'b ureed isqat al-hukouma*" [the people want the government down] because the street saw in the "Higher Authority" a manoeuvre to maintain the old regime, as if they are telling the people "go back to your homes and we will take care of you." Saied qualified the establishment of the "Higher Authority" as an "attempt to transform the *hirak* into something like a space shuttle that is launched by several engines and then the shuttle gets rid of them [the *hiraks*]." (Saied 2013) Salvaging the establishment, which is vital for the planned comeback of counter-revolutionary forces, involved the protection of its attributes, such as the markets, the media, and the security apparatus(es).

The Arab Democracy Index of 2016 shows that four years after the eruption of *dignity revolutions*, the scores of indicators concerning respect of rights and freedoms, equality and social justice, and strong and accountable institutions are down respectively by 49, 32, and 16 points (5%, 3%, and 1.5% accordingly), while the score of the indicators concerning rule of law significantly increased by 114 points (11.5%). (الشقاق، قسيس و حرب 2017، 7)

A closer look at the sub-indicators of the Index in the Tunisian case (figure (4)) shows that post-revolutionary change was not homogeneous. The direction of change in practice was oriented towards fostering the state apparatus, and providing impunity for governmental institutions. The change process was highly reliant on legislative and judicial reforms – the most obvious growth was in the score of indicators related to the rule of law. This, apparently, facilitated the growth of indicators reflecting the respect of rights and freedoms, albite not those rights that provide for equality and social justice. The single ever-dwindling indicator over the four-year period leading to 2015 is the one that is most representative of the demands of the revolution (equality and social justice).

**Figure (4): Classification of scores according to democratic practices in Tunisia:
Comparison of readings from 2010, 2012, and 2015**



Source: Arab Reform Initiative, Date set of the Arab Democracy Index – 5 (2017 5 مقاييس الديمقراطية العربي- (الشفاقي، كسييس و حرب، مقاييس الديمقراطية العربي- 5 (2017 5

The Tunisian case demonstrates that the changes that take place after a revolution, measured at a point in time, are the (temporary) resultant of the dynamics of the revolution and the counter-revolution. While local actors undertake revolution, the counter-revolution involves local as well as external actors who implement their agendas in legalised forms such as sanctions, loans, or through trade agreements, or through extra-judicial means involving the dispatching of militias or encouraging or financing such dispatching. Counter-revolutionary actors are not only those who acted to terminate the revolution, but also those who acted in contradiction with the anti-neoliberal demands of the revolution by promoting and radicalising neoliberal policies instead of furthering justice through socio economic equality.

Internal Actors

Both Egypt and Tunisia have undergone significant transformations under arrays of neoliberal reforms that preceded the *dignity revolutions*. Both were ranking high on the success scale according to various international reports. Tunisia was listed under the high human development countries with a HDI value of 0.683 in the Human Development Index of the UNDP, while Egypt was listed under the medium human development with a HDI value of 0.620. (United Nations Development Programme 2010, 144) The ongoing (successful) neoliberal reforms led to the emergence of a nouveau-riche class that treated government and security officials as their nomenklatura. The revolution posed a serious threat for them, but its success was unescapable. Hence, they resorted to diverting the *dignity revolutions*' goals – a task eased by the absence of direction and leadership in the revolutions.

The readiness of some forces that took part in the *dignity revolutions* to shrink and transform revolutionary goals facilitated the counter-revolutionary task. Amongst these forces were the Moslem Brothers in Egypt and the Ennahda Movement in Tunis (both right-wing, economic

liberal, socially conservative, and Islamist) in addition to some liberal forces. These forces contested the old regime's monopoly, but not its neoliberal politics. They postured as candidates for replacing the old corrupt regime. In essence, the actions of these parties diverted the meaning and significance of "dignity" from inclusion to exclusion. They reduced the revolutionary demands by excluding their socio-economic elements and maintaining the procedural part of the political dimension solely. A main tool for the realisation of the diversion technique was the media. Both local and regional media presented the dilemma of the nascent regime as being religious or civil. "Amongst the manoeuvres used by the regime to maintain itself was the indoctrination of public opinion that the main conflict is between Islam and infidelity, ... and the relegating of all key social, and even political issues." (Saied 2013) Yusra Ghannouchi, the international spokesperson for the Tunisian Ennahdha Party noted that "otherwise serious media" exaggerates the "ideological polarisation" by "cloaking every possible ... issue in the reductionist islamist-secularist dichotomy while ignoring other more insightful dimensions." (Ghannouchi 2014) This dichotomisation is one of the common denominators for those who wanted to avoid the actual anti-neoliberal quests of the *dignity revolutions*. These included protégés of the old regime, liberals, Islamists, the security apparatus, and the army (especially in the case of Egypt).⁸

The Islamic movements characterised the old regimes as secular rather than nationalist, capitalist, neoliberal, proxy, or any other quality of relevance to their failure. The global wave of islamophobia that the "clash of civilisations" doctrine nourished created an environment, in which sticking to Islamic identity seemed a dignified choice. The term "civil" in the context of post-revolutionary debates implicitly discounted secularity as an unacceptable option. The (neo)liberal and leftist forces characterised elected parties as "Islamist", rather than socially reactionary, or economically and politically mainstreamers (capitalist). The secular/religious divide helped camouflaging the agendas of liberal political parties that were also void of representing revolutionary demands. The result was a contestation between apolitically defined parties fostering the neoliberal post-political stance. Major media outlets like Al-Jazeera supported the indoctrination of the Islamist post-political identity. Director of Amnesty International Tunisia, Lutfi Azzouz indicated that:

... the revolution uncovered many things and revealed many wrong stereotypes. Examples are such beliefs that the Tunisian society is an open society that accepts equality, while the reality is the existence of racist discrimination based on colour, and agitation against Jews and Christians; and that Tunisian Islam is Zaitounian [in reference to the Zaitouna School], while the reality is the emergence of Takfiri [ex-communicational] trends. (Azzouz 2013)

Most likely these phenomena existed before the revolution (not the least because of the involvement of Tunisians in ranks of the *Mujahedeen* in Afghanistan), but the post-revolutionary prevailing discourse rather boosted these phenomena than revealed them.

The new political landscape allowed for what was referred to in Egypt as "safe exit" - a smooth "transition" to a "controlled democracy" (Kandil 2016, 375) through the ballot box in both Egypt and Tunisia. Both Islamic parties achieved unquestionable success in the elections in both countries before people were disenchanted with them shortly after their election. "Morsi had given the SCAF [Supreme Council of the Armed Forces], the secularists, the fulool, and, most importantly, the revolutionaries, a reason to return to Tahrir, which lead to his removal from power by the military on July 3, 2013." (Fahmy 2016, 91) Neither of the two parties was

⁸ For an account on the positions of various political actors combining historical presentation with a discussion of the most prominent writings on the issue see (Smet 2016).

responsive to the *dignity revolutions*' socio-economic demands. Their platforms do not involve equality, social welfare, inclusion, provisions for state-sponsored health and education, or poverty eradication. The new political leaders were not less neoliberal than the old regime. They even sacrificed the narrow platform of procedural democracy. In Egypt President Morsi waged an attack on labour unions offering "to share control of ETUF [Egyptian Trade Union Federation] with former Mubarak supporters" (Beinin 2016, 117), and "by December 2012, the Brotherhood was already flexing its muscles: snubbing military mediation and employing armed supporters to repress opposition ... Brothers not only endorsed the repression of attempts to reignite the revolt, but they actually blamed the victims." (Kandil 2016, 331-332) The agony between the various forces that played different roles in the post-revolutionary process, turned into antagonism after the Rabe'a massacre of 14 August 2013. The bloody act was a play of radicalisation within the anti-revolutionary camp. The army executed a coup against Brotherhood after the alliance between the two forces became unnecessary. (Sika 2022) Similar dynamics involving attempts to suppress the unions, (Beinin 2016, 121-128) and a popular protest against Ennahda took place in Tunisia.

The similarities between the ways the revolutions and counter-revolutions played out in Tunisia and Egypt are not a rule. Revolutions took multiple paths in different countries. Counter-revolutionary tactics also have similarities. A common tactic is reframing the revolutionary quest and transforming it by highlighting some new (invented or unearthed) frontier to replace revolution's designation. In Egypt and Tunisia the new regimes "invented" a legislative front that served reframing revolutionary demands, and achieving what Habermas calls "juridification", which signifies control through a growing body of regulatory tools (constitution, laws, and decrees). Along with an ever-growing security apparatus, this process resembles governmentality "being the 'conduct of conduct' means it conditions the very ways of people's thinking, acting and being." (Sadiki and Saleh 2020, 14)

The contestation amongst the new players frenzied, and involved some redistribution of powers, and political realignments. According to Shawki Tabib, part of the old Tunisian oligarchy operates under the auspices of Ennahda Movement, and count on its failure to come back to power. (Tabib 2013) "Elites have no intention to reach a reconciliation. The dragging of the debate over legislative texts was a coverage of the actual struggle." (Tabib 2013) "It is a struggle for existence under the disguise of the constitution ... they all dream on the same pillow and share a single dream: the Carthage Palace."⁹ (Saied 2013) Political elites made laboratory rats out of the masses experimenting on getting to power – "bit'alamou lihjama brous el-yatama [they learn cupping with the heads of orphans]." (M'Rad 2013)

In addition to utilising the media for indoctrination and distraction, there are other techniques that Taïeb Baccouche (General Secretary of Nida' Tunis Party at the time of the interview) listed as "the main tools for the reproduction of hegemonic structures: chaos, violence, absence of security, and the fear of terrorism." (Baccouche 2013) Typically, panic and lack of security are created through market mechanisms that threaten livelihoods – like a shortage in energy sources (petrol and electricity). Speculations in the media exacerbate the situation. *Asharq Al-Awsat* newspaper published in its business section three days before the coup de grâce street protests of 30 June 2013 is exemplary:

Egypt continues to face a deteriorating fuel crisis with the capital, Cairo, particularly hard hit, resulting in long lines of cars queuing up in front of gas stations blocking traffic.

⁹ It is worth reminding here that several years after declaring the struggle over the constitution a "disguise", Saied took over power on 25 July 2021 under the disguise of the constitution!

... Egyptian president Mohamed Mursi apologized for fuel shortages ... Mursi blamed the fuel crisis on unfounded media speculation and the illegal hoarding of fuel by some gas stations. (Yamani 2013)

Analysts are convinced, beyond any conspiracy theory, that the army designated the fuel crisis. (Sika 2022) Consolidating the techniques and tools and ensuring their service to the counter-revolutionary strategy requires the reproduction and maintenance of a central power depository that is capable of maintaining the results of various counter-revolutionary techniques, and regaining initiative through coercion, clientelism, and constant threat. “Counter-revolutionary forces act through the deep state, and seek to maintain chaos.” (Saied 2013)

The deep state hinges on two pillars: civil bureaucracy and the army, but the counter-revolutionary inversion requires the concentration of these two pillars through their unification, balancing, and subordination to a regulator/guardian of the old/new regime: typically, a bloated security apparatus. After the revolution, the Tunisian state succeeded in establishing the broad set of democratic institutional structures, but the counter-revolutionary forces managed to keep these changes hostage to the prevalence of their interests under the threat of coercion and chaos:

Almost all vital sectors in the country have undergone some change, but the impact is barely felt by Tunisians. The one area that has escaped change is security.

...

The Tunisian Police and National Guard have seen their numbers increase by more than 25,000 men between 2011 and 2015. (Boussen 2021, 4-5)

Furthermore, security forces are pushed into a confrontational relation with the masses through various means like the identification of security with the regime, and providing security with impunity:

Political complacency with police violence, coupled with inflammatory rhetoric from the police unions, is a perfect recipe for abuse. (Guellali 2021)

The direct impact of the internal counter-revolution is destabilisation, creating a favourable situation for oligarchy.

The existence of armed and quasi-military structures outside the state also create a strong feeling of instability while providing extra-judicial protection to certain segments of the population. This recreates inequality, fosters the notion of being a minority, and eventually results in destabilisation. The Arab Security Index of 2016 highlighted the “correlation between these [sectarian] affiliations and the attitudes and impressions of the public towards the security sector.” (2016) (الشقاقي، حرب و لدادة 2016) These and other techniques utilising “frontier” or “cleavage” creation to generate fear, chaos, and insecurity are supported and further exacerbated by the acts of external anti-revolutionary actors.

External Actors

Such problems as the deficit of fuel (whether real or not, and whether new or recurring) are frequently politically orchestrated/instrumentalised both at the internal and external fronts. For example, towards the end of 2014 Dr Ahmed Mokhtar, deputy editor in chief of Al Ahram Al Massai wrote in Khaleej Times magazine:

The 25th January revolution in 2011 and its security implications that reflected on investment climate made several international corporations suspend any new projects they planned to carry out in Egypt ...

... As the Egyptian government planned to attract huge investments during the coming period, it has become a challenge to provide the needed fuel that would supply new factories... (Mokhtar 2014)

In the same article there is another line that points to the importance of certain regional coalitions of the Egyptian regime, which benefited from “large quantities of oil products as an economic aid.” (Mokhtar 2014)

On the security level, the most effective and widespread technique of external counter-revolutionary intervention is the involvement of foreign or local militias that act upon foreign command and agendas. Frequently these militias, while challenging the regime, provide it with legitimacy by creating “demand” on combating what represents an “external enemy” of the state. This is the case in almost all countries where *dignity revolutions* erupted. When counter-revolutionary powers do not get a full grip over the state, the delineation of state and non-state actors becomes hazy. They together form a sort of a network of actors. The centrality of the state as a provider of security is revealed a fiction. Because the essence of statehood is security provision, when the state shares its essence with non-state actors, it becomes faint, thus creating a situation where social-revolutionary acts are not feasible or rational.

External, especially military intervention, is the antidote of democratisation. Out of four countries where the dignity revolutions took down regime symbols, two (Yemen and Libya) are in wars involving external military interventions. According to some analysts, the external intervention in Syria is what prevented a democratic outcome of the revolts, and turned the democratic *hirak* into a civil war. (متاع 2020) The Bahraini government invited forces from some seven countries to suppress protests in 2011, (Zarcom Media 2011) thus evading change.

In addition, there exists a “passive counter-revolution” - the insistence of external actors to maintain the course of their intervention with disregard to popular demands. The Pandemic allowed us to “discover anew the ubiquity of international power players that shape and dictate policy.” (Saleh and Sadiki 2020) For example, European Union foreign aid policy in the aftermath of the *dignity revolutions* showed no responsiveness, other than non-sustained lip service to the demands, chanted in revolution squares. It can be characterised as “marginalizing the question of social and economic rights as well as - to a slightly lesser extent - ... marginalizing the potential role of labour organizations.” (Teti 2015, 22)

The redline of external intervention is built on conjoining the interests and efforts of internal and external counter-revolutionary forces where some seek to maintain or regain power through destabilisation, and others seek to create beneficial geo-political positions at the cost of the livelihoods of other nations, leading to a multifaceted anti-revolutionary hegemony that furthers imperialist interests.

The Pandemic as a Bummer and a Catalyst

The pandemic cannot serve as a cause or as a result of democracy. “[V]ulnerability to crises (in this case, a global pandemic) in the Arab states is structural.” (Sadiki and Saleh 2020, 6) Problems and solutions existed before the pandemic in the Arab World and globally. Countries were poorly prepared as the pandemic broke out in early 2020. (Schiller and Hellmann 2021) The pandemic simply exacerbated the situation. The economy was hit and poverty hiked, but this was not new: “the [Arab] region is more unequal than even Africa or Latin America.” (Partridge 2021 [2011])

Education suffered, the poorer suffered more, or were simply deprived. Remote schooling is not the same as going to school, but even that is not accessible to more than half of the children in the Arab World:

[E]xcept for Gulf countries, the percentage of internet users varies between 2% to 78% in the Arab region, less than half of the population has an access to the internet in 9 countries (UNFPA ASRO 2021, 27)

This means that the future generation of democracy builders are less educated, less healthy, and more unemployed. Nevertheless, they have better clarity concerning the problem because the pandemic has deepened and exposed neoliberal politics perplexed with authoritarianism. A note of an Egyptian expert voiced to researchers from Freedom House is characteristic:

‘The military regime has used COVID-19 as an opportunity to further repress political activists, rights defenders, lawyers, journalists, and doctors, arresting dozens, denying them basic assistance in places of detention, and placing several on terrorist lists.’ (Repucci and Slipowitz 2020, 3)

Security and intelligence were at the frontline of procurement of COVID related items globally. Egypt’s trade and industry ministry coordinated with the military production ministry to expand the production of medical masks and to open a production line for cloth masks. (Ahram online 2020) In Palestine, the minister of health declared that her ministry received COVID testing related material from the chief of intelligence. (عكس التيار 2020) This phenomenon of security and army involvement in the civil aspects (the health system being a vivid example) is not only related to an unexpected pandemic. On the backdrop of a “failure” in the Tunisian health system leading to a surge in COVID-19 cases and deaths, on July 2021, after one and a half years since the emergence and spread of the COVID-19, the Tunisian President ordered the army to manage the pandemic, (بحر 2021) before he suspended the parliament, and took over the government less than a week later. (Parker 2021) The army and other internal, and possibly external, forces supported Saied’s acts. The pandemic was an initial excuse for the President’s monopolisation of power. Multiple excuses, not related to the pandemic, followed.

COVID-19’s perils have augmented the risks of human existence, especially for the have-nots: individuals, communities and states. Arabs are scrambling for new mediums—material, immaterial, moral and political—to weather the pandemic and its manifold socio-economic-political repercussions. Reflexivity as dialogue and debate can be one step in blunting the blows wrought by COVID-19. Risk might engender an opening for civic, political, and economic players to ponder policies and activism that can begin to reign in inequality, vulnerability, and exclusion in the Arab region. (Sadiki and Saleh 2021)

As was the case in Egypt, and in Sudan, counter-revolution can stagnate democratisation and even temporarily move it out of the horizon. Nevertheless, the next quest for it will be more radical. The lesson to be learned is that side-lining questions of justice and inclusion is a recipe for revolutionary failure.

The pandemic created a situation where the state of exception became normal rather than needing normalisation. “In some contexts, leaders and politicians have used the situation to advance nationalist political agendas, spread extremist ideologies, or find advantage in an ongoing contest for hegemony in the global political order.” (Bonotti and Zech 2021, xiii) With limited healthcare capacities during the peaks of the pandemic, loss of jobs, and the need for vaccination, managed by public healthcare systems of mostly clientelist regimes, the government became the conferrer of the “let live” largesse. The pandemic provided the oligarchs with a *raison d’être* for their hegemony, legitimised the build-up of their coercion, provided an augmented reality repetition in real time for a life where expression of opinion is likely to prove an excessive and futile exercise, made incarceration/lock-down a matter of command, and made doctors depend, in their professional practice, on security officials.

On the other hand, the pandemic translucently exposed the performance of Arab regimes, their political systems, government structures, and capacities. It underlined all what the *dignity revolutions* contested. The exhibited inability and lack of capacity during the pandemic reduced

the trustworthiness of these regimes to a zilch. The story of a young Iraqi civil servant is characteristic:

'The vaccine has come here so fast, ... but that's so strange. In Iraq, with things like this, you usually can't get access without some corruption, or you have to pay somebody. But it [the vaccine] is for free and it's available for everybody. It's a bit suspicious.' (Schaer 2021)

The emerging picture is sarcastic. The regime acts to control the lives of the citizens. It requires loyalty, which the neoliberal traditions transpose into one-way compliance (involuntary loyalty). A dilemma soars: on one hand, the government promotes policies where each is responsible for their own fate; on the other hand, lockdowns and the unavailability, or lack of access to vaccination and hospitalisation threaten people's fates.

Conclusion: The Post-Pandemic Bifurcation

The pandemic polarised the political landscape. All conflicts that were concealed by compromises and temporary solutions are up for an essential resolution. Managing or camouflaging conflicts under the disguise of development, peacebuilding, state building, and reconciliation is exposed. The twinning of liberalism and democracy exhausted itself: liberalism has grown into neoliberalism, which is prone to oligarchy - not democracy; liberalism does not assume equality, while democracy does; the peak of liberal democracy in the West was conditioned on the divide of the three worlds that were reorganised; and the increasing spread of populism will not leave much room for plurality, or rights. Any direction that does not prioritise equality and inclusion is counter-revolutionary.

The ways in which these global dynamics might express themselves in the Global South, including the Arab World are multiple. The end game will depend on the battle between democratic and oligarchic camps. The current era in the Arab World is one of change. The pandemic put a clutch on its speed, but increased its torque. "Longstanding uprisings that have brought down leaders from Lebanon to Iraq have largely left the streets as COVID-19 stifles public life. But that hasn't stopped protesters from pursuing political change". (Allinson and Sanders 2020) The forced delay of street action led to a "hibernation" of the *hiraks*, but the devastation and poverty that dominated the scene, together with the weakening of the middle class are likely to facilitate a stronger next burst of the *dignity revolutions*. Albeit this will not guarantee the success of the *hiraks*, nor the success of their repercussions such as democratisation, equality, protection of dignity, and emancipation. The war over the future is not teleological. It can take unforeseen turns as the revolts, *hiraks*, the pandemic, and the counter-revolution unfold.

The goals of a next round of the *dignity revolutions* will, likely, be more fundamental after the readily available liberal democracy blue print stopped being a satisfactory model of socio-political organisation. Now Arab rebels are tasked with the invention of a new model – a new world order. The current order is more stable in the Global North, and the global South is the weak link in the chain. The simple reproduction of the neoliberal order in the conditions of crony capitalism, rentier economy, surging unemployment, low quality education, debt, high consumption, and external hegemony is unlikely to succeed. Thus, there are chances that an aggravated global turmoil will start in the Global South. Since the eruption of the *dignity revolutions*, the Arab World became a strong and trained candidate for igniting the quest for change. What the globalisation achieved is that no part of the world can be isolated any more, but the global chain is as strong as its weakest link.

The Arab oligarchy and its allies regionally and globally, recognising this scenario, are likely to radicalise. The rules of the game might become more brutal, delaying the change process,

resulting in bloodier battles, and requiring a more comprehensive range of resources for fighting the oligarchy. The emotional urge for revolt as a reaction to indignation will not be sufficient:

The very logic of the emergency state, then, is to prevent us from doing what really should be done. Today more than ever, we need a thinking which is not a simple reflexive response to the state of emergency. (Zizek 2009)

In the final account, the democratic emancipatory mission of the Arab street is a sophisticated and complex one. Its success hinges on securing an array of conditions: the invention and shaping of a next epoch; the invention of new modes of political organisation; the fostering of broader and stronger coalitions of emancipatory powers on grounds of solidarity; the twinning of local struggle against the local oligarchies with the struggle against neo-colonial arrangements that nourish the global oligarchic hegemony; and the theoretical development of a revolutionary strategy.

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